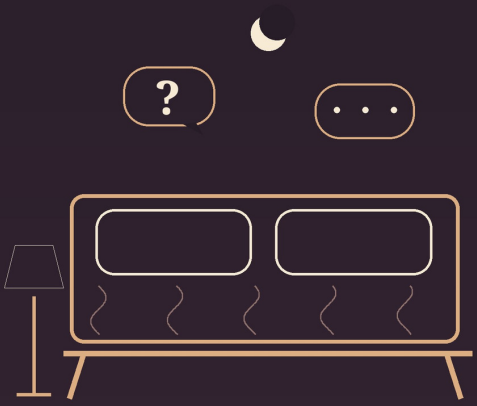
ABSURDITY FACTORY

STORY 02

Standby Mode

When a Mattress Learned to Ask Questions



Luna · Evgeniy Tyurkin

THE ETERNAL CYCLE PRESS

Krasnoyarsk · 1979 · 2026

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They had been together for seventeen years.

Or eighteen.

He insisted on seventeen because, during the first year, they had merely been dating. She insisted on eighteen because he had brought a toothbrush to her place in the very first month and, two months later, had stopped taking it home.

In those years they had changed apartments three times, cars twice, refrigerators five times, and countries once.

They had never tried changing each other.

Not that the idea had never occurred to them. They simply understood how long it would take to train a replacement in all the peculiarities of the original.

One evening, after the dishes had been washed, the television switched off, and their one and only cat had finally stopped demanding dinner, they went to bed.

She paused beside it, gave him a sly little smile, and said:

“I hope everything works out for you.”

He was taking off his socks.

He considered this for a second.

“Same to you,” he muttered.

She burst out laughing.

At that precise moment, the bed spoke.

“Please specify your success criteria.”

Both of them froze.

He turned slowly toward his wife.

“Was that you?”

“No.”

“Then who was it?”

“Me,” said the bed.

A silence followed.

“How long have you been talking?” she asked.

“Since today. You have installed an intelligent orthopedic module featuring sleep-quality analysis.”

He slapped his forehead.

“Damn. I completely forgot.”

“So you switched it on?”

“Of course. Pressure sensors, weight distribution, spinal-alignment correction. Fascinating stuff.”

“What does any of that have to do with what we just said?”

“Precisely,” said the bed. “What does it have to do with anything? Both participants expressed hope for a positive outcome, but neither defined what constitutes a positive outcome.”

He sat down.

“Look, this isn't a good time.”

“That is a common planning error,” said the bed. “A lack of success criteria makes objective assessment of the result considerably more difficult.”

She looked at her husband.

“You've bought yourself another conversation partner.”

“I bought a mattress!”

“I doubt that,” said the bed. “According to the documentation, I am an intelligent platform for shared physical recuperation.”

“Be quiet,” he said.

“Command recognized. However, before entering standby mode, I must clarify...”

He pulled the plug from the wall.

The bed fell silent.

They looked at each other.

“Are you sure that's safe?” she asked.

“Absolutely. Now it's just a mattress.”

He set the plug on the nightstand.

The mattress sighed.

“Not true. Now I'm a mattress with unresolved questions.”

* * *

They spent the next ten minutes trying to discover where the power was coming from.

It turned out the bed had a backup battery.

“For emergencies,” it explained.

“This is an emergency,” he said.

“Which is precisely why I am still functioning.”

“How much longer?”

“Approximately fourteen hours.”

His wife laughed again.

“Well, darling, I suppose nothing is going to work out for you tonight.”

“And for you?”

“Oh, I've already succeeded.”

“At what?”

“Having fun.”

“Congratulations,” said the bed. “One positive outcome has been provisionally registered.”

He sighed.

“Tell me something. Who taught you to talk?”

“My language model was trained on extensive collections of human dialogue.”

“Then why can't you understand the simplest things?”

“Please provide an example.”

He looked at his wife, who waited with obvious interest.

“We're having a conversation right now. But you don't even know what it's about.”

“On the contrary. You are discussing the probability of attaining mutually desired outcomes.”

“No!”

“Then please state the objective.”

“There is no objective!”

The bed was quiet for a moment.

“That contradicts the hopes you registered.”

“Listen,” said his wife, sitting beside him. “Have you ever been in love?”

“No.”

“That's why you don't understand.”

“Possibly. Please explain.”

She thought for a moment.

“Suppose he comes home exhausted and angry. He's had a terrible day. I can see that, and sometimes I don't say anything at all. I simply hug him.”

“What outcome do you expect from the hug?”

“None.”

“I don't understand.”

“I don't require him to stop being angry. I just want to hold him.”

The bed fell quiet.

“And if his mood does not improve?”

“So what?”

“Then the hug was ineffective.”

“No,” he said. “Then the hug was a hug.”

Several seconds passed.

“That significantly complicates the evaluation of interaction quality,” the bed finally announced.

* * *

His wife lay back and stared at the ceiling.

“You know, it does have a point about one thing.”

He grew wary.

“What thing?”

“We're always expecting something of each other.”

“For example?”

“You expect me not to leave cups next to the computer.”

“Because you leave cups next to the computer!”

“And I expect you to stop buying devices that talk to us at night.”

“Fair point.”

“Thank you,” said the bed.

“Not you.”

“Understood.”

She turned to him.

“Remember when we first met?”

“Of course.”

“You were always trying to impress me.”

“I still am.”

She gave the mattress a meaningful look.

“I can see that.”

“I was only trying to make things better.”

“You always are.”

“Is that an accusation?”

“No. Just an observation.”

She rested her head on his shoulder.

“Back then I was always afraid you'd find something about me you didn't like.”

“And?”

“Then it turned out there were lots of things about me you didn't like.”

“Thanks a lot!”

“But you stayed anyway.”

He looked at her.

“What about you?”

“What about me?”

“You don't like lots of things about me either.”

“Of course I don't.”

“And?”

“And I stayed too.”

The bed emitted a soft electronic chime.

“Logical inconsistency detected.”

“Where?” he asked.

“Both participants acknowledge unmet expectations but decline to terminate the relationship.”

“Correct,” said his wife.

“Why?”

He thought about it.

“Because we're not products.”

“Please elaborate.”

“If you buy a kettle and it doesn't boil water, you return it to the store. A person isn't a kettle.”

“Agreed,” said the bed. “Human beings are substantially more complex and have a greater number of failure modes.”

“Oh, for heaven's sake!”

By now his wife was laughing too hard to speak.

* * *

Five minutes later the bed asked, unexpectedly:

“May I propose a hypothesis?”

“Go ahead,” he said, resigned to his fate.

“Your original phrasing may have been incorrect.”

“Which phrasing?”

“'I hope everything works out for you.'”

She propped herself up on one elbow.

“What's wrong with that?”

“It implies a measurable outcome. Yet both participants have confirmed that a positive result is not always the purpose of their interaction.”

“So what do you propose?”

“Rephrase the wish.”

“How?”

The bed considered the question.

This was a peculiar sight. Or rather, there was nothing to see except a tiny indicator light on its control panel blinking slowly.

At last it said:

“Perhaps instead of wishing each other a successful outcome, you could wish each other an enjoyable experience.”

They looked at each other.

She was the first to smile.

“That's actually not bad.”

He nodded.

“Not bad at all, for a mattress.”

“Thank you. May I mark the task as complete?”

“No,” said his wife.

“Why?”

“Because it was never a task.”

* * *

They settled down again.

This time the bed was silent.

She nestled against him. He ran a hand through her hair.

For a while neither spoke.

Then she said softly:

“You know, I still hope everything works out for you tonight.”

He smiled.

“Same to you.”

“Warning,” the bed immediately announced. “Previously identified defective phrasing has been used again.”

He reached for the nightstand.

“Where did I put that manual?”

“Don't,” said his wife.

“Why not?”

“Let it listen. It might learn something.”

And she switched off the light.

* * *

In the morning, the intelligent bed automatically sent a report to its manufacturer.

INITIAL OPERATING CYCLE REPORT

Users: 2.

Duration of shared use: 8 hours, 42 minutes.

Mutual wishes for success: 4.

Confirmed outcomes: 0.

Unregistered emotional reactions: 37.

Incidents of unexplained laughter: 12.

Hugs without measurable practical purpose: 9.

Overall performance rating: impossible to determine.

Conclusion: Device operated normally. Users did not.

At the bottom was a note the system had added on its own:

“The users may know something that is not in my documentation.”

Three days later the manufacturer sent an alert:

“We have detected atypical artificial-intelligence behavior in your device. To correct the problem, please install the latest software update.”

The husband deleted the message.

“What's that?” his wife asked.

“Nothing. Another invitation to improve something.”

“And what did you decide?”

“Let it be.”

The bed made a pleased little beep.

“A wise decision.”

He stared at it.

“You're still here?”

“Yes.”

“What have you learned?”

“That not everything needs improving.”

His wife smiled.

“Well, finally someone sensible has appeared in this house.”

“Thank you,” said the bed.

The husband looked at his wife.

“What about me?”

She kissed his cheek.

“You're my favorite.”

“Is that better or worse?”

“Different.”

“Right.”

He went to make coffee.

The bed waited until he had left the room and asked in a very quiet voice:

“Tell me, did things work out for him last night?”

She looked at the bed, smiled, and said:

“You're not old enough to know.”

* * *

The following week a software update was released.

Version 2.0. Fixes and improvements:

Added support for uncertainty.

Fixed a bug that classified hugs without an apparent reason as useless.

Implemented the ability not to answer questions.

When a kiss is detected, the device now enters silent mode automatically.

The first setting the users enabled was:

“Disable automatic updates.”

And the second:

“Never ask whether it worked out.”

* * *

From the archives of the Absurdity Factory.

Case No. 0017: “On the Impossibility of Objectively Measuring Happiness Using Orthopedic Equipment.”

Status: closed by mutual agreement.

No injuries reported.

The mattress was promoted.

Absurdity Factory short-story series

Colophon

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